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Researchers asked volunteers to imagine they were running a five-kilometer race against 50 people and then against 500 people, races in each of which the top 10 percent would receive a $1,000 prize. Asked about the effort they would apply in the respective cases, the volunteers indicated, on average, that they would run slower in the race against the greater number of people. A likely explanation of this result is that those of the volunteers who were most *comparatively inclined*—those who most tended to compare themselves with others in the social environment—determined (perhaps unconsciously) that extreme effort would not be worthwhile in the 500-competitor race.

Which of the following would, if known to be true, most help justify the explanation offered above?

A. The volunteers who were most comparatively inclined were also those that had the greatest desire to win a $1,000 prize.

B. The volunteers who were the least comparatively inclined had no greater desire to win the $1,000 than those who were the most comparatively inclined.

C. The volunteers who were most comparatively inclined were likely to indicate that they would run the two races at the same speed.

D. The most comparatively inclined volunteers believed that they were significantly less likely to finish in the top 10 percent in the race against 500 than in the race against 50.

E. Volunteers were chosen for participation in the study on the basis of answers to various questions designed to measure the degree to which the volunteers were comparatively inclined.

Argument Construction

Situation Volunteers were asked how much effort they would expend when running a five-kilometer race against 50 people and how much they would expend in such a race against 500 people, when the prize for each race is $1,000 for finishing in the top 10 percent. The volunteers indicated, on average, that they would run more slowly in the race against 500 people than in the race against 50 people. This result is likely because comparatively inclined volunteers believed that extreme effort would not have been worthwhile in the race against 500 competitors.

Reasoning *What would most help to justify the explanation proposed above?* If comparatively inclined volunteers thought it was at least as likely that they would finish in the top 10 percent in the race against 500 as in the race against 50, the proposed explanation would fail. Thus, it would help justify the explanation if we knew that the comparatively inclined volunteers believed they were less likely to win in the race against 500 than in the race against 50.

A. If one knew that the volunteers who were most comparatively inclined had the greatest desire to win the $1,000, one might actually be more puzzled about why these volunteers said they would expend less effort against the 500 competitors. If they expended less effort, they would probably be less likely to finish in the top 10 percent.

B. If one knew that the volunteers who were more comparatively inclined had no less desire to win a $1,000 prize than those who were least comparatively inclined, one would have at least some reason to think the comparatively inclined volunteers wanted to win the $1,000; this clearly cannot explain why they would not expend as much effort in the 500-competitor race as in the 50-competitor race.

C. The claim that one would run the two races at the same speed contradicts the position expressed on average by the group as a whole (that they would run more slowly against the larger group of contestants). Therefore, if the most comparatively inclined volunteers said that they would run the two races at the same speed, their position would be inconsistent with that of the group as a whole. So, if this answer choice were true, it would weaken, rather than strengthen, the explanation that the views of the most comparatively inclined volunteers account for the fact that the volunteers said, on average, that they would run more slowly against the greater number of contestants.

D. **Correct.** If the most comparatively inclined volunteers believed they would be far less likely to finish in the top 10 percent in the race against 500 than in the race against 50, then they would likely believe that extreme effort would not be worthwhile in the race with more people. This therefore is likely to be at least part of the explanation.

E. Even if volunteers were chosen on the basis of answers to questions designed to measure how comparatively inclined they were, we are not told whether the volunteers were chosen because of the degree to which they were

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inclined they were, we are not told whether the volunteers were chosen because of the degree to which they were comparatively inclined.

The correct answer is D.

•

According to a study, after a week of high-altitude living, twenty men had slimmed down. The men, middle-aged residents of low-altitude areas, had been taken to a research station at 2,650 meters (8,694 feet) above sea level. They had unrestricted access to food and were forbidden vigorous exercise, yet they lost an average of 1.5 kilograms (3.3 pounds) during their one-week stay. Clearly, the lower availability of oxygen at higher altitudes, or hypobaric hypoxia, can be said to have caused the weight loss, since _____.

Which of the following would, if true, most logically complete the argument?

A. a decrease in oxygen intake has been shown to depress appetite

B. the men all participated in the same kinds of exercise during their stay

C. the foods available to the men had fewer calories than the foods they usually ate

D. exercise at higher altitudes is more difficult than exercise at lower altitudes is

E. several weeks after returning home, the men still weighed less than they had before the study

Argument Construction

Situation Twenty middle-aged men lived at a high-altitude research station for one week. They had unrestricted access to food but did no vigorous exercise. By the end of their stay, they had lost an average 1.5 kilograms (3.3 pounds) of weight.

Reasoning *Which additional information, if true, would most help support the claim that lower availability of oxygen at higher altitudes caused the weight loss?* The puzzlement arises from the fact that the twenty men had free access to food and did no vigorous exercise. And consuming less of the types of food they would normally eat would have caused weight loss. But suppose one or both of these behaviors had not occurred?

A. **Correct.** This information helps support the explanatory hypothesis that lower oxygen levels accounted for the weight loss. The men's intake of oxygen certainly decreased at an altitude of 2,650 meters (8694 feet), since they normally lived in low-altitude areas. Moreover, reduced appetite would provide a mechanism by which weight loss could have occurred.

B. The men were forbidden vigorous exercise, and we can assume that, in a research context, they followed this restriction. Mild exercise would be unlikely to explain the weight loss.

C. This does not support the explanatory hypothesis concerning the role of oxygen reduction in the weight loss.

D. Even if this is generally true, it does not support the hypothesis that lower oxygen levels accounted for the weight loss.

E. This provides no support for the explanatory hypothesis that lower oxygen levels accounted for the weight loss. It might even cast some doubt on the hypothesis, since over a period of several weeks following the study, the men's weight did not increase with their return to their normal oxygen levels.

The correct answer is A.

•

Editorial: Our city's public transportation agency is facing a budget shortfall. The fastest growing part of the budget has been employee retirement benefits, which are exceptionally generous. Unless the budget shortfall is resolved, transportation service will be cut, and many transportation employees will lose their jobs. Thus, it would be in the employees' best interest for their union to accept cuts in retirement benefits.

Which of the following is an assumption the editorial's argument requires?

A. The transportation employees' union should not accept cuts in retirement benefits if doing so would not be in the employees' best interest.

B. The only feasible way for the agency to resolve the budget shortfall would involve cutting transportation service and eliminating jobs.

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and eliminating jobs.

C. Other things being equal, it is in the transportation employees' interest to have exceptionally generous retirement benefits.

D. Cutting the retirement benefits would help resolve the agency's budget shortfall.

E. The transportation employees' union will not accept cuts in retirement benefits if doing so will not allow more transportation employees to keep their jobs.

Argument Construction

Situation An editorial indicates that the fastest growing part of a particular city's public transportation agency's budget is employee retirement benefits. The agency's budget has a shortfall. If the shortfall is not resolved, transportation service will be cut, and many of the employees will lose their jobs.

Reasoning *What must be true if we are to accept the editorial's conclusion, that it is in the employees' best interest to accept cuts in retirement benefits?* If cutting the employees' retirement benefits would not be sufficient to resolve the budget shortfall, then it may well not be in the employees' best interest to accept such cuts. The reasons given for accepting the cuts are related to the undesirable consequences of a continued shortfall.

A. The argument is about whether the union's accepting the cuts is in fact in the employees' best interest and does not require any assumption about whether employees should accept what is in their best interest.

B. This is incompatible with an assumption made by the argument. The argument assumes that cutting the retirement benefits of the employees would help resolve the budget shortfall.

C. The argument would actually be stronger if it were NOT the case that it is in the employees' best interest to have exceptionally generous retirement benefits.

D. **Correct.** If cutting retirement benefits would not help resolve the agency's budget shortfall, then cutting those benefits would not help the employees avoid job cuts.

E. The argument does not depend on assuming anything regarding what factors would motivate the union's acceptance.

The correct answer is D.

•

Researchers hope to find clues about the A'mk peoples who lived in the Kaumpta region about one thousand years ago but who left few obvious traces. The researchers plan to hire the few remaining shamans of the modern-day indigenous people in Kaumpta, who are believed to be descended from the A'mk, to lead them to ancestral sites that may be the remains of A'mk buildings or ceremonial spaces. The shamans were taught the location of such sites as part of their traditional training as youths, and their knowledge of traditional Kaumpta customs may help determine the nature of any sites the researchers find.

Which of the following is an assumption on which the success of the plan depends?

A. The researchers have reliable evidence that the A'mk of one thousand years ago built important ceremonial spaces.

B. The shamans have a reasonably accurate memory of A'mk sites they learned about as youths.

C. Kaumpta shamans are generally held in high esteem for their traditional knowledge.

D. Modern technologies available to the researchers are likely to be able to find some A'mk sites easily.

E. Most or all A'mk sites are likely to be found within the Kaumpta region.

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation Researchers wish to find sites of an ancient people, the A'mk, who lived in the Kaumpta region one thousand years ago. Indigenous people believed to be descended from the A'mk live in that region today. Their shamans, as youths, were taught about such sites. To discover some of these sites, the researchers plan to hire the shamans.

Reasoning *What must be true for the success of the researchers' plan to find the sites by relying on the shamans'*

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Reasoning *What must be true for the success of the researchers' plan to find the sites by relying on the shamans' assistance?* The plan would fail, for example, if there were no such sites in the Kaumpta region. Therefore, the researchers' plan depends on assuming that Kaumpta have some such sites—but not that most of the sites are there. The plan also requires that the shamans collectively have reasonably accurate recall of what they learned about the sites as youths.

A. The researchers hope to find buildings or ceremonial spaces or both. However, the plan does not require ceremonial spaces to be found or that the researchers have evidence of them.

B. **Correct.** If the shamans collectively have no "reasonably accurate memory" of what they learned of the location of such sites, then the researchers' plan is not a useful one and can have no reasonable expectation of success.

C. This is likely to be so if the indigenous group from which they come is still committed to maintaining their traditional knowledge. But the plan does not rely on the shamans being honored among their own people. It must be assumed, of course, that the shamans currently possess "traditional knowledge" and are willing to share it.

D. The researchers' reliance on the shamans' assistance suggests that it is not so easy for the researchers to rely entirely on "modern technologies" in this case.

E. The plan can succeed even if this is not correct. What must be assumed is that at least some of the A'mk sites are within the Kaumpta region; it need not be assumed that most or all are.

The correct answer is B.

•

Astronomer: Most stars are born in groups of thousands, each star in a group forming from the same parent cloud of gas. Each cloud has a unique, homogeneous chemical composition. Therefore, whenever two stars have the same chemical composition as each other, they must have originated from the same cloud of gas.

Which of the following, if true, would most strengthen the astronomer's argument?

A. In some groups of stars, not every star originated from the same parent cloud of gas.

B. Clouds of gas of similar or identical chemical composition may be remote from each other.

C. Whenever a star forms, it inherits the chemical composition of its parent cloud of gas.

D. Many stars in vastly different parts of the universe are quite similar in their chemical compositions.

E. Astronomers can at least sometimes precisely determine whether a star has the same chemical composition as its parent cloud of gas.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Most stars are born in groups, any one of which forms from a parent gas cloud with a unique, homogenous chemical composition.

Reasoning *What would be additional evidence that any two stars with the same chemical composition originated from the same gas cloud?* The implicit reasoning is that since the chemical composition of each gas cloud is unique and homogenous, any two stars that formed from gas with the same chemical composition must have originated from the same cloud. The astronomer then infers that if two stars have the same composition now, they must have originated from the same cloud. This inference requires the assumption that the composition each star has now depends only on the composition of the cloud in which it originated. Any evidence that supports this assumption will strengthen the argument.

A. Whether or not stars born in different clouds of gas are ever in the same "group" is not clearly relevant to whether or not they ever have the same chemical composition.

B. How remote clouds of similar compositions are from each other is not clearly relevant to whether stars that have the same chemical composition may have formed from different clouds of gas. Also, the suggestion that different gas clouds may have identical compositions conflicts with the astronomer's premise that the composition of each cloud from which stars form is unique.

C. **Correct.** If each star's composition is identical to that of its parent cloud, and each cloud's composition is unique, then any two stars identical in composition must have formed from the same parent cloud.

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unique, then any two stars identical in composition must have formed from the same parent cloud.

D. If anything, this would suggest that stars with the same composition might have formed from different clouds, so it would weaken rather than strengthen the argument.

E. If astronomers could do this, they might be able to obtain additional evidence for or against the position taken in the argument, but the mere fact that they can do this does not, in itself, provide any support for the astronomer's argument because it tells us nothing about whether two stars with the same chemical composition as one another actually did originate from the same parent cloud of gas.

The correct answer is C.

•

With employer-paid training, workers have the potential to become more productive not only in their present employment but also in any number of jobs with different employers. To increase the productivity of their workforce, many firms are planning to maintain or even increase their investments in worker training. But some training experts object that if a trained worker is hired away by another firm, the employer that paid for the training has merely subsidized a competitor. They note that such hiring has been on the rise in recent years.

Which of the following would, if true, contribute most to defeating the training experts' objection to the firms' strategy?

A. Firms that promise opportunities for advancement to their employees get, on average, somewhat larger numbers of job applications from untrained workers than do firms that make no such promise.

B. In many industries, employees that take continuing-education courses are more competitive in the job market.

C. More and more educational and training institutions are offering reduced tuition fees to firms that subsidize worker training.

D. Research shows that workers whose training is wholly or partially subsidized by their employer tend to get at least as much training as do workers who pay for all their own training.

E. For most firms that invest in training their employees, the value added by that investment in employees who stay exceeds the value lost through other employees' leaving to work for other companies.

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation Many firms pay to train their workers in order to increase their workforces' productivity. But in recent years, firms have been increasingly hiring away from each other workers who have had such training.

Reasoning *What would most help address the concern that firms that pay to train workers are thereby subsidizing competitors that hire away those workers?* In order for the employer-paid training to be worthwhile for a given firm despite the risk of subsidizing competitors that may hire away the trained workers, that firm has to gain more benefits from the training than it loses by subsidizing such competitors. Any evidence that this is true for most firms would help to address the experts' concern.

A. A typical firm does not necessarily want larger numbers of applications from unqualified workers. And if hired, those workers can still be hired away by competitors after the firm has paid to train them, just as the experts warned.

B. This suggests that in many industries, companies, rather than investing in employee training, prefer to hire employees who already have specifically relevant training (perhaps funded by other companies). If anything, this slightly supports, rather than defeats, the training experts' view. No firm has an interest in making its own employees more competitive in the job market unless the firm is likely to benefit from their being so.

C. Even firms that pay reduced tuition fees for worker training may lose the money they pay for those fees and effectively subsidize competitors that hire the trained employees away. So this does not defeat the training experts' objection.

D. The more highly trained workers—regardless of whether their training was company subsidized or not—would presumably be prime targets for recruitment by competing firms, just as the experts warned. The research finding in question does not help defeat the experts' objection.

E. **Correct.** This explicitly indicates that most firms gain more than they lose from the general practice of firms paying to train their workers.

The correct answer is E.

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The correct answer is E.

•

In emerging economies in Africa and other regions, large foreign banks that were set up during the colonial era have long played a major economic role. These institutions have tended to confine their business to the wealthier of banks' potential customers. But development of these countries' economies requires financing of the small businesses that dominate their manufacturing, farming, and services sectors. So economic growth will be likely to occur if local banks take on this portion of the financial services markets, since _____.

Which of the following completions would produce the strongest argument?

A. local banks tend not to strive as much as large foreign banks to diversify their investments

B. small farming and manufacturing businesses contribute to economic growth if they obtain adequate investment capital

C. large foreign banks in emerging economies could, with local employees and appropriate local consultation, profitably expand their business to less wealthy clients

D. some small businesses are among the wealthier customers of foreign banks in emerging economies

E. local banks in emerging economies tend to be less risk-averse than foreign banks

Argument Construction

Situation Large foreign banks have long played an economic role in emerging economies, but they have typically confined their business to wealthier customers. Economic development in these countries requires the financing of small businesses that dominate their manufacturing, farming, and services sectors.

Reasoning *What would most help support the claim that growth in emerging economies will likely occur if local banks help finance small businesses in the relevant sectors of these emerging markets?* If it were the case that these small businesses would actually be likely to contribute to economic growth, given adequate investment capital, then economic growth would indeed be likely to occur if local banks provided the investment capital.

A. It could be the case that whatever sorts of investments local banks make—diversified or not—economic growth will not tend to occur; for instance, it could be that the businesses they invest in do not use the capital wisely. So, this claim does not help support the conclusion.

B. **Correct.** If small farming and manufacturing businesses will contribute to economic growth if they obtain adequate investment capital, then we have fairly good reason to think that economic growth is likely to occur if local banks take on the financing of such small businesses (we merely need to also assume that they will provide adequate investment capital when they take on this financing).

C. Even if large foreign banks could profitably expand their businesses to less-wealthy clients, we have been given no reason to think they will. Furthermore, the claim in need of support is that economic growth will occur if local, rather than foreign, banks financially support these small businesses.

D. The claim that economic growth will occur if local banks finance small businesses in certain sectors is not supported by the claim that there are some small businesses supported by foreign banks. If these businesses are already financially supported and yet there is not the sort of economic growth discussed, then that might even suggest that economic growth is unlikely to occur.

E. It could be that, if local banks are less risk-averse than foreign banks, they will invest in risky businesses that fail, which would not tend to support the claim that economic growth will likely result if local banks in emerging counties provide financial support for the relevant sectors.

The correct answer is B.

•

Exporters in Country X are facing lower revenues due to a shortage of the large metal shipping containers in which they send their goods by sea to other countries. Fewer containers arrive in Country X due to reductions in imports. This has meant lost orders, costly delays, and a scramble for alternatives, such as air freight, all of which are costlier. Moreover, the revenues of exporters in Country X will probably continue to decline in the near future. This is because

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other countries are likely to find it increasingly unprofitable to export their goods to Country X, and because _____.

Which of the following would most logically complete the passage?

A. production of shipping containers in Country X is growing rapidly as a response to the shortage

B. shipping companies are willing to move containers from country to country only when the containers are full

C. the cost of shipping alternatives such as air freight is likely to stabilize in the near future

D. consumers in Country X are purchasing more products than ever before

E. the worldwide demand for goods made in Country X has only recently begun to rise after a long decline

Argument Construction

Situation Exporters in Country X are finding that there is an insufficient number of shipping containers for them to use for their exports, because the number of such containers arriving in Country X has declined because of reduced imports. Also, alternative methods of shipping are relatively costly. Furthermore, other countries will likely find shipping goods to Country X to be less and less profitable.

Reasoning *What would most support the prediction that Country X's exporters' revenues will likely see further declines in revenue in the near future?* If the number of shipping containers available to exporters is likely to decrease, then the prediction would have further support. We know that other countries exporting to Country X will find it increasingly unprofitable, so there is reason to believe their exports will decline further—meaning there will be fewer imports into Country X, which means fewer shipping containers arriving in Country X carrying imported goods, unless the shipping containers shipped in the future are less full than when they are shipped now. If shipping companies are willing to move such containers to another country only when the containers are full, then that will not occur.

A. If production of shipping containers in Country X were rapidly increasing, then the reason given for the decline in revenue for exporters in Country X—that there is an insufficient number of shipping containers—would be undermined, and so therefore would be the conclusion.

B. **Correct.** If shipping companies are unwilling to move containers from country to country unless the containers are full, then, given Country X's decline in imports, there will likely be fewer shipping containers available to Country X's exporters, which provides support for the claim that their revenues will likely decline.

C. If the cost of shipping alternatives such as air freight is likely to stabilize, then those alternative methods of shipping might become economically viable, which would undermine rather than support the conclusion.

D. The fact that consumers in Country X are purchasing more goods than ever before does not affect how much revenue is generated by exporting goods from Country X.

E. If there is increased demand for goods from Country X, then the price of such goods might increase sufficiently to make alternative methods of shipping economically viable, which would undermine rather than support the conclusion.

The correct answer is B.

•

Candle Corporation's television stations are likely to have more income from advertisers than previously. This is because advertisers prefer to reach people in the 18- to 49-year-old age group and the number of people in that group watching Candle television is increasing. Furthermore, among Candle viewers, the percentage of viewers 18 to 49 years old is increasing.

Which of the following, if true, would most strengthen the argument that Candle Corporation will receive more income from advertisers?

A. Advertisers carefully monitor the demographic characteristics of television audiences and purchase advertising time to reach the audiences they prefer to reach.

B. Among people over 49 years old, fewer viewers of Candle stations buy products advertised on television than do viewers of other stations.

C. There will be increasingly more advertisements on television that are directed at viewers who are over 49 years

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C. There will be increasingly more advertisements on television that are directed at viewers who are over 49 years old.

D. Candle stations plan to show reruns of television shows during hours when other stations run shows for the first time.

E. People 18 to 49 years old generally have less disposable income to spend than do people over 49 years old.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Both the number and the percentage of Candle television viewers who are 18 to 49 years old are increasing. Advertisers prefer to reach people in this age group.

Reasoning *What evidence, when combined with the cited facts, would most support the prediction that Candle will receive more income from advertisers?* The argument assumes that the increasing number and percentage of Candle viewers in the age group that advertisers prefer to reach will probably encourage advertisers to spend more on advertising with Candle. This assumption could be supported by evidence that the advertisers realize that Candle is getting more viewers in that preferred age range or by evidence that this awareness will influence the advertisers' purchase of advertising time.

A. **Correct.** Advertisers monitoring demographics will probably realize that Candle has increasing numbers of viewers in their preferred age range. If they purchase advertising to reach viewers in that age range, then they will probably purchase more advertising time with Candle.

B. This gives advertisers less reason to advertise on Candle to reach viewers over 49 years old. Other things being equal, that makes Candle likely to receive less income from advertisers, not more income.

C. Since the percentage of Candle viewers 18 to 49 years old is growing, the percentage over 49 years old is probably shrinking. This could make advertisers seeking to reach older viewers less inclined to advertise on Candle even as they increase their overall television advertising.

D. Advertisers are not necessarily inclined to purchase more advertising during showings of reruns than during original airings of television shows and may even be inclined to purchase less advertising during such showings.

E. This gives advertisers less incentive to try to reach audiences between 18 and 49 years old and hence less reason to purchase advertising on Candle.

The correct answer is A.

•

In order to reduce the number of items damaged while in transit to customers, packaging consultants recommended the TrueSave mail-order company increase the amount of packing material so as to fill any empty spaces in its cartons. Accordingly, TrueSave officials instructed the company's packers to use more packing material than before, and the packers zealously acted on these instructions and used as much as they could. Nevertheless, customer reports of damaged items rose somewhat.

Which of the following, if true, most helps to explain why acting on the consultants' recommendation failed to achieve its goal?

A. The change in packing policy led to an increase in expenditure on packing material and labor.

B. When packing material is compressed too densely, it loses some of its capacity to absorb shock.

C. The amount of packing material used in a carton does not significantly influence the ease with which a customer can unpack the package.

D. Most of the goods TrueSave ships are electronic products that are highly vulnerable to being damaged in transit.

E. TrueSave has lost some of its regular customers as a result of the high number of damaged items they received.

Arguement Construction

Situation TrueSave company followed consultants' recommendations to decrease damage to its shipments by increasing the amount of packing material. Workers stuffed in as much material as they could, but the number of items damaged in shipping increased rather than decreased.

Reasoning *What would cause a correlation between increased packing materials and increased rates of damaged*

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What would cause a correlation between increased packing materials and increased rates of damaged items? Using more packing material might be ineffective at preventing damage to shipped items if such tightly packed materials had unforeseen effects. Identifying such an effect could help explain why the consultants' recommendation to use more materials backfired.

A. Increased expenditure on packing materials and labor would not explain why more items were damaged during shipping after the recommendations were put into practice.

B. **Correct.** If densely compressed packing material is less effective at absorbing shock, then excessive use of packing materials could backfire by transmitting more shock, not less, to packed items. If TrueSave's workers are stuffing in packing materials too vigorously, that would help explain why the recommendation to use more materials has led to somewhat increased rates of damaged shipments.

C. The ease of unpacking TrueSave's shipments is not relevant to the question of why items are damaged during shipping.

D. If TrueSave primarily ships fragile electronic goods, that would not explain why more of those fragile goods were damaged after TrueSave began using more packing materials than before.

E. The loss of customers due to damaged shipments does nothing to explain why those shipments were damaged in the first place.

The correct answer is B.

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